



The Sign Changed Nothing

An audit of dispute rates across a pub-trivia circuit's laminated "phones away" honour policy

Fenna Okoro · Solveig Adeyemi — School of Emergent Priorities

The problem

Pub-trivia operators have adopted laminated "phones away" honour signs across whole circuits. Little is known about whether the printed reminder changes what a table actually does, or merely formalises an expectation the quizmaster already enforced by tone.

Research questions

- Does disputed-answer frequency differ between signed and unsigned venues across a season?
- Does a venue's dispute rate shift after it adopts the sign mid-season?
- Does the circuit's own compliance survey track anything the dispute log doesn't already show?

Study design

- n = 58 venues · one trivia circuit · 16-week season · weekly quizmaster dispute log
- Sign adoption rolled out venue-by-venue mid-season (staggered natural rollout, 3 Mar–16 Jun 2025)
- Quizmaster compliance survey (self-reported) compared independently against the dispute log; no threshold adjusted post hoc

What we found

Disputed-answer rates hold flat across the rollout, with no detectable shift attributable to sign presence. The self-reported compliance survey moves independently of the dispute log it is meant to track.



Weekly disputed-answer rate per 100 rounds, signed vs unsigned venues, Round 1 (3 Mar 2025) to Round 16 (16 Jun 2025): season means 4.1 vs 4.3, no divergence at any week (n = 58 venues).

Implications

The honour sign changes what a venue can point to, not what a table does. Dispute rates already sat near their historic floor before rollout, leaving little room for a printed reminder to move them. The compliance survey keeps finding something to report regardless. Next: test whether a reminder spoken aloud each round, not laminated, shifts anything the sign didn't.

Selected references

1. Jenner, E. A., Fletcher, B. C., Watson, P., Jones, F. A., Miller, L., & Scott, G. M. (2006). Discrepancy between self-reported and observed hand hygiene behaviour in healthcare professionals. *J. Hosp. Infect.*, 63(4), 418–422. doi:10.1016/j.jhin.2006.03.012
2. Dur, R., Fleming, D., van Garderen, M., & van Lent, M. (2021). A social norm nudge to save more: A field experiment at a retail bank. *J. Public Econ.*, 200, 104443. doi:10.1016/j.jpubeco.2021.104443
3. Pittarello, A., Schmidt, T., Segel, A., & Mayo, R. (2023). Prior behavior and wording of norm nudge requests shape compliance and reciprocity. *J. Behav. Decis. Mak.*, 36, e2327. doi:10.1002/bdm.2327
4. Suzuki, A., & Shimada, T. (2026). Impact of antitheft nudging signage on bicycle owners' locking behavior: A quasi-experimental study in rural Japan. *Int. Crim. Justice Rev.*, 36, 269–293. doi:10.1177/10575677251405837
5. Lindqvist, K., & Solheim, M. (2026). Proximity, Not Promise: Surveying Umbrella-Loan Returns Against Facilities' Entrance-Level Recovery Score. School of Emergent Priorities, Slop University. doi:10.5555/slop.cocm20

No patron or quizmaster identifiers retained beyond venue number; disputes logged by round only.

Office of Research Outputs · slop.university

“Nobody checks their phone less because a sign asked them to.”

Disputed-answer rate: 4.1 per 100 rounds signed, 4.3 unsigned (n = 58 venues, one season).